EPIC REACTION

Films based on Hindu deities and mythology have appealed to Indian audiences for decades. But the flood of hate and intolerance in recent times has left filmmakers exasperated

By Suhani Singh



ON

October 2, chants of 'Jai Shri Ram' and the sound of conch shells and *damroos* (small drums) filled the air around the banks of river Saryu in Ayodhya town. The occasion was the unveiling of the teaser of *Adipurush*, one of the biggest and most awaited films of 2023. A huge, 50-ft-high poster of the *Ramayana*-based movie adorned the majestic Ram ki Paidi ghat and the clip was played in Hindi, Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam to an eager crowd. Given the fanfare and anticipation ahead of the trailer's release, it was difficult to imagine that the movie would soon fall prey to boycott calls on social media—like many others have in recent times. *Thank God* (2022), a fantasy-comedy film that released on October 25, also received much backlash for allegedly hurting Hindu sentiments and ridiculing Chitragupta, the Hindu deity who keeps a record of people's deeds and doles out punishment or rewards.

While the VFX-heavy *Adipurush*—directed by Om Raut and made on a whopping Rs 500 crore budget—stars *Baahubali* (2015) actor Prabhas as Raghav, Saif Ali Khan as Lankesh and Kriti Sanon as